I praised the Rasha forum, which constitutes the management of the Mossad. These are people who have accumulated hundreds of years of experience among them, and because covert affairs are learned in the field rather than in academia, their combined experience is priceless. They are people who are tough, who tend to say little and keep their feelings hidden. I also commended the Varash forum, stressing that the cooperation among Military Intelligence, the Shin Bet, and the Mossad, through which each body contributes its unique abilities, creates a force multiplier that brings about results that no one body could produce alone. Finally, I expressed my support and best wishes to the Mossad's employees and operatives scattered across the globe, including in enemy countries, whose actions guarantee the security of the people and the State of Israel.

I thought that the occasion of my acceptance of the position, in the presence of the prime minister and others, merited the expression of my thoughts, and my remarks lasted a few minutes. I remember that while I was speaking the prime minister leaned over to the person standing next to him and whispered, "I never knew that Shabtai could speak!" I had met with Prime Minister Shamir several times before that ceremony, in various meetings and contexts, but I had never said, whether in response to a question or at my own initiative, more than the minimum required to express my opinion on the issue at hand. I had always felt that the prime minister's time was a precious commodity and that his status required reverence both in speech and in behavior. Thus to him I appeared to be "the silent type"—which incidentally, could have described him as well—and, as the saying goes, I have never regretted the things I did not say.

The ceremony ended with a toast and a tasting of Jerusalem's famous *burekas* (savory stuffed pastries) served in the prime minister's bureau, and then everyone went on their way. I drove from Jerusalem toward the coastal plain, and, with a feeling of awe, I entered the office of the director of the Mossad and took my seat on the chair that I had gazed upon for so many years.

The late 1980s and early 1990s, during which I served as director of the Mossad, were a historic crossroads in the world order. The geopolitical and geostrategic transformations that took place during this period were of a magnitude and weight the likes of which had not been seen since the end of World War II. During these years, the State of Israel witnessed the following milestones: